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Ailment



The days of the doctor who detects disease in the patient's appearance, gait and pulse, well before ordering a test, are almost gone. For patients it means spiralling costs.

ENDLESS TESTS

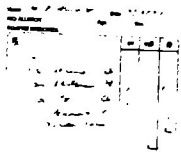
"The easy availability of diagnostic tests has led to physicians banking more on tests," says Dr Anoop Misra, head of metabolic disorders at Fortis Hospital, Delhi. The fallout? More expensive and complex tests; indiscriminate use of potent drugs; 'buckshot therapy' of combination drugs in the hope that the patient will respond to one or the other; spiralling surgical interventions; unnecessary and often more invasive tests.

Prescription

Though a certain amount of testing is essential, the Health Ministry should break the unholy nexus that often exists between diagnostic centres and doctors.

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A popular joke, but a serious problem. A fourth of all medical errors are due to illegible prescriptions. The risk of getting a similar-sounding but wrong drug is far too real.

BAD HANDWRITING

In November 2008, the Bombay High Court made a radiologist sign an affidavit pledging to improve her handwriting. With a host of similar-sounding drugs, the risk of drug substitution is very high: Arkamine (blood pressure) for Artamine (rheumatoid arthritis); Isoprime (to raise BP) for Isoptine (to bring down BP); Digene (antacid) for Digoxin (heart failure); Magna (respiratory infection) for Magfa (depression).

Prescription

Implement the demand made by the Indian Medical Association for computerisation of all prescriptions and documentation of recovery.

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Ask any doctor about hospitals and they will tell you one thing: keep away from them. Infection spread from hospitals is rampant in the country.

SECONDARY INFECTIONS

The incidence of post-operative infection in India varies from 10 to 25 per cent, about one-third of which can be prevented (5 per cent globally). With a hand-rub solution costing more than Rs 500, most hospitals find spending on infection control expensive, while surgeons, according to research done by the Hospital Infection Society of Pune, often do not pay attention to the basic cleanliness guidelines in ORs.

Prescription

Regulating authorities must enforce sanitary norms, including sterilisation standards, and cancel the licences of offending hospitals.

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Something hurts? The easy way out for a doctor is to send you off with a painkiller. Sleeping pills and anti-depressants are heavily over-prescribed across the country.

DRUG DEPENDENCY

"The daily use of relief medication interferes with the body's own pain-fighting systems," says Dr K. Ravishankar of Jaslok Hospital, Mumbai. Overuse of codeine and combination analgesics can rebound and the 'cure' can become the 'cause'. Doctors often prescribe anti-anxiety medicines for common ailments just to make the patient feel better. No wonder, Alprazolam is the most over-prescribed drug in India.

Prescription

Strict regulation of chemists by CDSCO to ensure sale of drugs only with prescriptions and spread awareness among patients about dangers of self-medication.